CHAPTER 22

TIPTOEING THROUGH THE MILKY WAY

I swear by the shelters of the stars (a mighty oath, if you but knew it) …

—THE QUR'AN, SURA 56 (7TH CENTURY)

Of course, it is strange to inhabit the earth no longer,
To give up customs one barely had time to learn …

—RAINER MARIA RILKE, "THE FIRST ELEGY" (1923)

The prospect of scaling heaven, of ascending to the sky, of altering other worlds to suit our purposes—no matter how well intentioned we may be—sets the warning flags flying: We remember the human inclination toward overweening pride; we recall our fallibility and misjudgments when presented with powerful new technologies. We recollect the story of the Tower of Babel, a building "whose top may reach unto heaven," and God's fear about our species, that now "nothing will be restrained from them which they have imagined to do."

We come upon Psalm 15, which stakes a divine claim to other worlds: "[T]he heavens are the Lord's, but the Earth hath he given to the children of men." Or Plato's retelling of the Greek analogue of Babel—the tale of Otys and Ephialtes. They were mortals who "dared to scale heaven." The gods were faced with a choice. Should they kill the upstart humans "and annihilate [their] race with